'Excuse me,' I said, tapping him on the shoulder. 'I understand what you're saying. As it happens, there are two agents who want to get involved right now. If you would really like to help, would you mind speaking to them both and then letting me know what you think? I would value your opinion.'

He agreed, and did indeed call me three days later. He didn't think there was anything wrong with either of the agents, but said he thought I needed to find someone who was going to do more than arrange a few commercial deals and take 10% of my earnings. He said I needed someone I could trust, who would assemble a professional support team, who would be able to help me through a very busy period of my life.

'Someone like who?' I asked.

'I don't know,' he replied.

'Will you do it?' I asked.

He seemed ready for the question. 'I'll be happy to help you,' he said, 'but this is the only way it will work. I will create and lead the professional support team and we'll manage everything so you can focus on your cricket. In return, I don't want a commission on anything. In fact, I'll never take a cent from you. What I do want is your commitment to apply yourself completely to being the best cricketer you can possibly be.

'And don't think this is a great deal because you can save some money and carry on as usual on the quiet. There are rarely any secrets in professional sport, and this is not going to be three strikes and you're out. This is going to be one strike and you're out. People talk, and if I hear of you being anything less than fully committed, in any way, or if you are ever less than completely honest, then we'll simply stop everything.'

'OK, that's fine,' I agreed.

This arrangement duly started in December 2007 and it remains in place almost nine years later. I have kept my side of the deal, and he has been incredibly helpful and supportive to me. He says he does not want payment: first, because he earns a living elsewhere and, second, because